

Chicken Wild Rice Soup

Whole bird · wild rice-forward · thick, spoon-coating, Upper Midwest style

YIELD	TIME	POT	STOCK
~6 L · 10–12	1.5 / 3.5 hr	8 qt+ · 2 vessels	2500 g, no reduction

INGREDIENTS

stock = body + fat · the base = chicken flavor

BIRD & STOCK		SOUP BASE		FINISH	
Whole chicken 4.5–5 lb, giblets out	2.0–2.3 kg	Unsalted butter up to half as skimmed chicken fat	150 g	Pulled chicken all of it	~650–900 g
Cold water	4000 g	Yellow onion diced	360 g	Cooked wild rice all of it	~1.1 kg
Onion halved, unpeeled	150 g	Carrots diced	270 g	Heavy cream	430 g
Carrot rough chop	100 g	Celery diced	270 g	Kosher salt start; finish to taste	10 g
Celery rough chop	100 g	Cremini sliced	400 g	Black pepper fresh ground	4 g
WILD RICE		Garlic minced	22 g	Lemon juice the acid	18 g
Wild rice true, not a blend	325 g	All-purpose flour	110 g	Parsley chopped	15 g
Water	1800 g	Dry sherry	55 g		
Salt like pasta water	to taste	Homemade stock strained	2500 g		
		Better Than Bouillon Roasted Chicken	30 g		
		Dried thyme	2 g		
		Bay leaves	2		

KEY TARGETS

the cues that decide the pot

Poach water	Bare simmer, 180–195°F — surface shivers, a stray bubble. A boil clouds the stock and tightens the meat.
Pull the bird	Thickest thigh 175–180°F , leg wiggles loose — about 50–70 min.
Wild rice	Most kernels split open. Lake/hand-parched ~20–30 min; glossy black paddy ~45–60 min.
Sweat & roux	Butter foaming, never browning; vegetables soft with no color. Roux 2–3 min — smells toasty, stays blond.
Thickness	Coats the back of a spoon before the rice goes in — the rice thickens it further.
Cream in	Last, heated through below a boil.

Taste only after the chicken and rice are in. About 2 kg of unseasoned meat and rice goes in at the end and soaks up salt — a base that tastes right before them tastes flat after. Expect to go past the 10 g of salt; add it in small hits.

Execution

METHOD

rice + vegetable prep run during the carcass simmer

- 1 **Poach:** chicken, cold water, and the stock onion, carrot, celery in the pot. Bring up to a **bare simmer (180–195°F)**, skim foam for the first 15 min. Poach until the thigh reads **175–180°F**, about 50–70 min.
- 2 **Pull:** lift the bird out; keep the pot at a bare simmer. Cool 15 min, strip all meat, discard skin, shred bite-size. Bones and cartilage back into the pot.
- 3 **Carcass:** **covered**, bare simmer **60–90 min**. Covered = no reduction.
- 4 **Rice (meanwhile):** rinse, then simmer covered in the 1800 g water, salted like pasta water, until most kernels split. Drain.
- 5 **Strain:** strain the stock, skim the fat and save it. Weigh out **2500 g** for the soup (short? top up with water); keep the extra for leftovers. Dissolve the base in a ladle of the hot stock.
- 6 **Sweat:** clean pot, butter (up to half swapped for the chicken fat) until foaming. Onion, carrot, celery until soft with no color, ~10 min.
- 7 **Mushrooms:** cook until their liquid is gone and the edges brown, ~10 min. Garlic, 1 min.
- 8 **Roux:** flour over the vegetables, stir **2–3 min** until it smells toasty and coats everything. Stays blond.
- 9 **Liquid:** sherry in, scrape the bottom. Whisk in the stock **a ladle at a time** (a dump makes lumps), then the dissolved base, thyme, bay, and **5 g** of the salt. Bring to a simmer.
- 10 **Simmer:** uncovered **20–30 min**, scraping the bottom as you stir (the roux settles and scorches), until the raw-flour taste is gone and it coats a spoon.
- 11 **Finish:** bay out. Chicken, rice, cream in; heat through below a boil. **Now taste** — salt in small hits, pepper, then lemon off the heat. Parsley.

TROUBLESHOOTING

three dials: base · salt · lemon

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Weak on chicken	Poach stock is light by nature	More base, a little at a time — before more salt (the base is salty)
Flat overall	Chicken + rice absorbed the salt	Salt in small hits, stir, re-taste
Heavy, dull	Cream + roux with no lift	More lemon, a little at a time, off the heat
Too thin	Short simmer / rice not in yet	Simmer longer; it sets up further as it sits
Scorched bottom	Roux settled, not scraped	Move to a clean pot without scraping the burnt layer
Leftovers set solid	Wild rice keeps absorbing in the fridge	Thin with the saved stock when reheating